

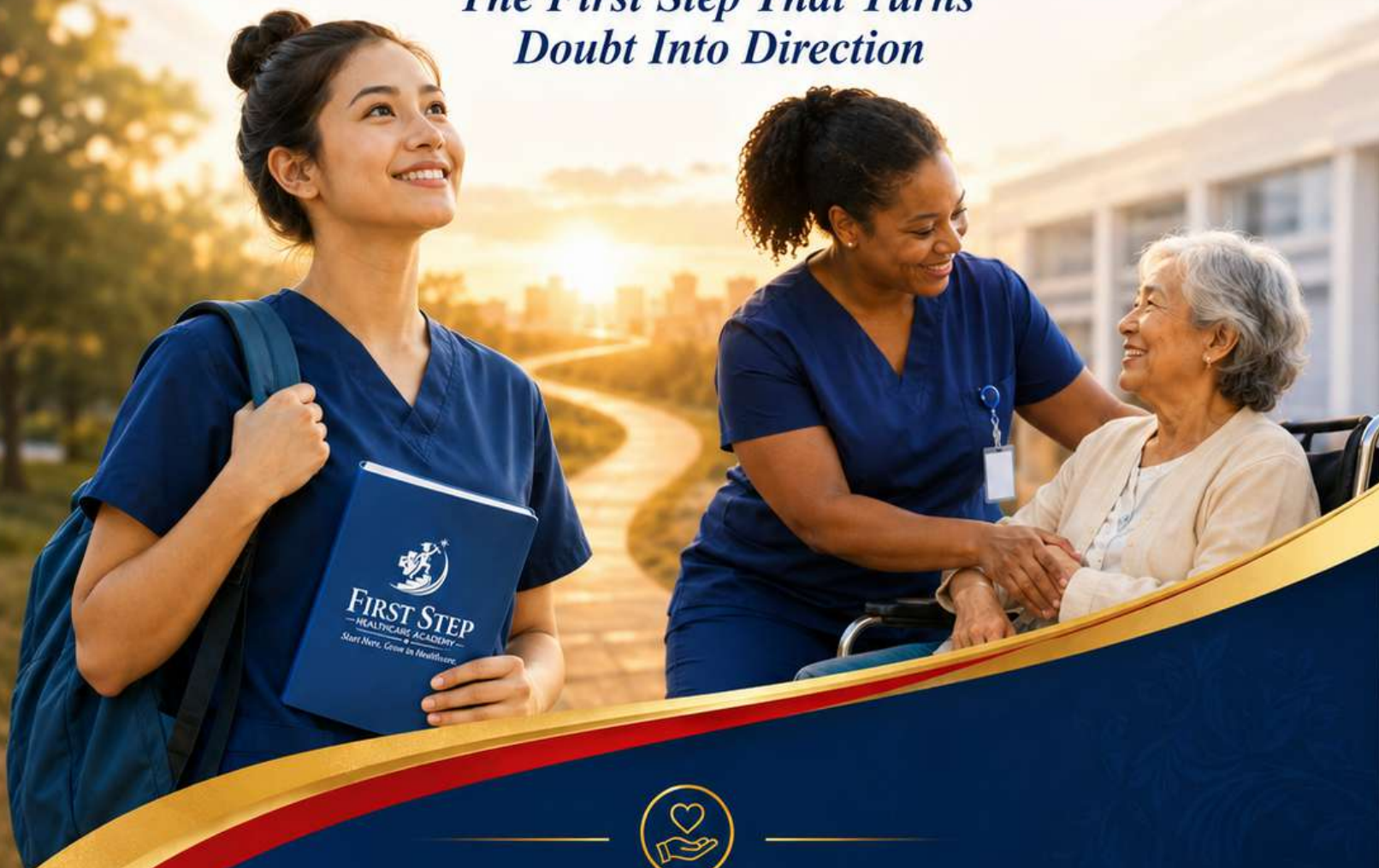


FIRST STEP
— HEALTHCARE ACADEMY —

Start Here. Grow in Healthcare.

CNA CAREER STARTER GUIDE

*The First Step That Turns
Doubt Into Direction*



A guide to patient care, training,
work settings, and future nursing growth.

A Meaningful First Step.

A STRONGER FUTURE.

This guide will help you discover the heart of CNA work, the doors it can open, and the confidence you can build along the way.



AT THE HEART OF CARE



Care

Compassion
in Action



Safety

Protecting
Well-Being



Dignity

Respecting
Every Person

You make a difference every day.

1. The First Step That Turns Doubt Into Direction

It is okay if you are not completely sure yet. Maybe you are thinking about becoming a nurse one day and want to strengthen your application to nursing school. Maybe you are looking for a stable healthcare job, a flexible income to support your family while building a better future.

You do not need to have the whole path figured out before you begin.

Sometimes, the first step is what helps you understand the rest of the path.

CNA can give you a way to start building direct patient-care experience, confidence, and healthcare skills. For future nursing students, that experience may help strengthen your application for LVN, ADN, BSN, or RN programs. For working adults and parents, CNA training may open the door to healthcare job opportunities with flexible schedules that still allow you to be present for the family.

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*“ Even if you start in the dark,
the first step turns doubt into direction. ”*

It simply means you are at the beginning. This guide is here to serve as a compass at the start of your journey, helping you discover how one meaningful step today can open doors to a future filled with growth, purpose, and confidence.

2. What Does a CNA Actually Do?

At the heart of CNA work is helping people through the moments of daily life when they need support the most. CNAs assist residents and patients with basic care needs such as bathing, dressing, grooming, eating, walking, transferring, toileting, and staying safe. They may also take vital signs, observe changes, report concerns to nurses, and help keep the care environment clean, respectful, and comfortable.

But CNA work is more than completing tasks. CNAs provide comfort, dignity, and reassurance during some of the most personal moments of care. For many residents and patients, CNAs are the familiar faces they trust each day. Through kindness, patience, and genuine human connection, CNAs help people feel safe, respected, and less alone.

CNAs also play an important role in the healthcare team. Because they often spend the most direct time with residents and patients, they may be the first to notice changes in condition, mood, appetite, mobility, or comfort. Reporting those changes can help nurses and care teams respond sooner.

For future nurses, CNA work can build early patient-care confidence, healthcare communication skills, and a deeper understanding of how care teams work. For those seeking stable healthcare work, CNA training can build practical skills that open the door to a stable and growing-demand career.



At its core, CNA work is about helping people feel seen, heard, and cared for during some of life's most vulnerable moments.

3. Where Can CNAs Work?

One advantage of becoming a CNA is that patient care is needed in many healthcare settings. CNAs may work in skilled nursing facilities, assisted living communities, hospitals, rehabilitation centers, hospice care, home care, and other long-term care environments. Each setting gives students a different view of healthcare and a different way to build experience.

Common CNA Work Settings

Work Setting 	Best Fit For 	Potential Advantages 	Work Style Notes 
1  Skilled Nursing Facility	 New CNAs wanting strong hands-on experience	 Common entry point, many openings, strong bedside-care experience	 Can be busy and physically active; often multiple shifts.
2  Assisted Living Community	 Students wanting a gentler start in care	 Relationship-building, less medically intense, daily resident support	 Often focused on routine care and independence.
3  Hospital	 Future nurses wanting acute-care exposure	 Strong healthcare-team exposure, hospital experience, possible higher competitiveness	 Faster pace; may be harder to enter as a new CNA.
4  Rehabilitation Center	 Students interested in recovery and mobility	 Transfer skills, body mechanics, therapy-team exposure	 Active setting focused on recovery and function.
5  Home Care	 Parents, students, or second-income workers	 One-on-one care, possible schedule variety, potentially shorter commute depending on client location	 More independent; requires reliability and professionalism.
6  Hospice Care	 Compassionate students comfortable with emotional care	 Meaningful work, family communication, dignity-focused care	 Emotionally sensitive; best for mature, patient caregivers.



Building Your Healthcare Network

CNA work can also help you begin building relationships in the healthcare industry. For future nursing students, CNA experience may help you build healthcare references, understand workplace expectations, and become familiar with the types of employers you may apply to later. A positive work record as a CNA can help show that you already understand the responsibility of patient care. Reliability, kindness, teamwork, communication, and professionalism can become part of your reputation.

For those seeking stable healthcare work, different CNA settings may help you discover which environment fits your personality, schedule, family responsibilities, and long-term goals.



4 More Settings Can Mean More Options

For working adults, parents, and students, this flexibility can provide practical advantages. Having access to multiple healthcare settings may make it easier to find opportunities closer to home, which can reduce commute time and make daily schedules more manageable.

Different employers may also offer different shift options, including day, evening, overnight, weekday, weekend, full-time, and part-time schedules. This can be especially helpful for students completing nursing school prerequisites, parents balancing family responsibilities, or individuals transitioning into healthcare while maintaining another job.



Closer to Home

Find opportunities near where you live to save time and reduce commute.



Flexible Schedules

Choose from day, evening, overnight, weekday, weekend, full-time, or part-time shifts.



Work-Life Balance

Build a schedule that supports school, family, and personal responsibilities.



Paths to Your Goals

Gain experience, build skills, and move forward toward your future in healthcare.





4. What to Expect in CNA Training

You are guided step by step. ✦

CNA training is designed to help beginners learn with instructor support along the way. Your instructor helps you understand the basics, practice safely, build confidence, and prepare for real patient care. Confidence comes from showing up, practicing, asking questions, and improving step by step with support along the way.

The CNA Training Journey — ✦ —

 Step	 What Happens	 How Your Instructor Guides You
1  Learn the Basics	Learn resident rights, safety, infection control, communication, body mechanics, and basic care concepts.	Your instructor explains key concepts, answers questions, and helps connect lessons to real care situations.
2  Practice Skills	Practice handwashing, vital signs, transfers, feeding assistance, personal care, and mobility support.	Your instructor demonstrates skills, observes your practice, gives feedback, and helps you improve through repetition.
3  Clinical Experience	Provide care in a supervised healthcare setting.	Your instructor guides you through real care situations, supports professionalism, and helps you connect classroom learning to patient care.
4  State Exam Preparation	Review knowledge, practice skills, and learn what to expect for certification testing.	Your instructor helps you organize what you learned and prepare for the written and skills portions of the exam.
5  Begin Your Healthcare Path	After completing training and certification requirements, students can explore CNA work and future healthcare goals.	Your instructor helps you understand how training can support your next step into healthcare.



Every step you take in training builds the confidence you need for the difference you'll make in care.

**FIRST STEP**

HEALTHCARE ACADEMY

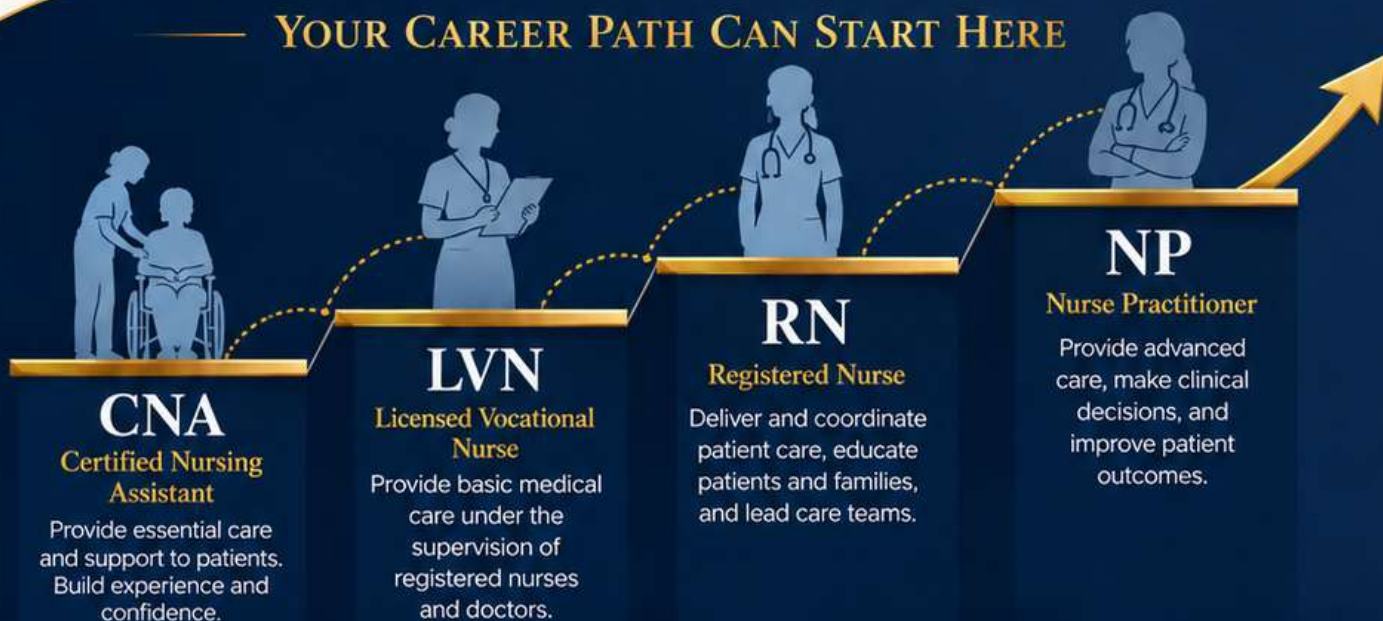
Start Here. Grow in Healthcare.

5. The First Step That Can Change Your Future

Many healthcare careers grow in steps. Some students begin as CNAs to strengthen their nursing application. Others start because they need income, stability, or a practical entry into healthcare. With additional education, program admission, licensing, and experience, some students may choose to grow toward LVN, RN, BSN, or even advanced nursing roles such as Nurse Practitioner.



YOUR CAREER PATH CAN START HERE



Every Great Career Has a Beginning.
Yours Can Start Today.

Start with your CNA training, build your skills, and take confident steps toward the future you deserve.

✦ **Start Here. Grow in Healthcare.** Your future in nursing begins with the decisions you make today—and we're here to guide you every step of the way.



SECTION 5

CAREER GROWTH SNAPSHOT

A quick look at how nursing roles can grow in responsibility, pay, and long-term opportunity.

 ROLE	 WHAT THIS ROLE CAN REPRESENT	 CALIFORNIA WAGE SNAPSHOT	 DEMAND / OUTLOOK
 LVN	A licensed nursing role with more responsibility than CNA and a practical next step for some students.	 California LVNs average \$77,170/year; top 10% earn \$99,840+.	 Nationally projected to grow 3% from 2024–2034, with about 54,400 openings/year.
 RN	A broader nursing role with more career mobility, specialty options, leadership paths, and patient-care responsibility.	 California RNs average \$140,330/year; top 10% earn \$208,880+. LA–Long Beach–Anaheim RNs average \$133,440/year.	 California projected growth is 13% from 2022–2034, with about 23,420 annual openings. Nationally, about 189,100 RN openings/year are projected.
 NP	An advanced nursing role with graduate education, diagnosis/treatment responsibilities, and high long-term growth potential.	 California NPs average \$166,610/year; top 10% earn \$234,800+.	 Nationally projected to grow 40% from 2024–2034, with about 29,500 openings/year.



You deserve a future with growth, stability, purpose, and opportunity.

The journey may take time, effort, and sacrifice, but it can also be deeply rewarding. Every skill you learn, every resident you help, every shift you complete, and every challenge you overcome can become part of the person you are becoming.



Use the **OC Nursing School Pathway Guide** for detailed information on ADN, BSN, ABSN, GPA, TEAS, and local nursing school planning to help you take the next step with confidence.

*“ You do not have to become everything overnight.
You only need to begin in a direction that can grow with you. ”*



189,100

RN OPENINGS PROJECTED
NATIONALLY EACH YEAR



40%

NP ROLE GROWTH
PROJECTED (2024–2034)



54,400

LVN OPENINGS PROJECTED
NATIONALLY EACH YEAR



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The Timing Will Never Be Perfect. Take the First Step.



At First Step Healthcare Academy, students are guided step by step as they learn patient-care skills, practice safely, prepare for clinical experience, and build confidence for the road ahead.



Guided Step by Step

Learn with support every step of the way.



Patient-Care Skills

Build the skills that make a difference.



Clinical Preparation

Practice safely. Gain real-world readiness.



Confidence for the Road Ahead

Grow in confidence—and in your future.



Scan the QR code to view
upcoming CNA classes,
request program information,
or speak with admissions.



Your future in *healthcare* starts here.

— START HERE. GROW IN HEALTHCARE. —